GLOUCESTER
ZAKAT FUND
CHARITY FOR LOCAL RESIDENTS

WHISTLEBLOWING POLICY

Document Information	
Policy Name	Whistleblowing Policy
Version	1.0
Policy Owner	Board of Trustees
Whistleblowing Lead	**Abdullah AS Patel**
Approved by	Board of Trustees
Date Approved	01/02/2026
Next Review Date	01/02/2028
Related Policies	Complaints Policy, Safeguarding Policy, Anti-Money Laundering Policy

1. Introduction

Gloucester Zakat Charity ("the Charity") is a Charitable Incorporated Organisation established to prevent and relieve poverty and financial hardship in Gloucestershire and the wider United Kingdom, with a particular focus on members of the Muslim community. The Charity collects and distributes Zakat (obligatory Islamic almsgiving) and Sadaqah (voluntary charity) to eligible beneficiaries.

The Charity is committed to the highest standards of integrity, honesty, and accountability. We recognise that, even in the best-run organisations, things can go wrong. The Charity encourages a culture of openness where anyone who has genuine concerns about wrongdoing feels able to raise them without fear of reprisal.

This policy sets out how concerns about wrongdoing can be raised and how they will be handled.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to:

- Encourage individuals to raise concerns about wrongdoing within the Charity
- Provide clear guidance on how to raise concerns
- Ensure that concerns are taken seriously and investigated appropriately
- Protect those who raise concerns in good faith from unfair treatment
- Demonstrate the Charity's commitment to transparency and accountability

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All trustees of the Charity
- All volunteers
- Partner organisations working with the Charity
- Beneficiaries
- Donors and members of the public
- Any other person who has concerns about wrongdoing within the Charity

4. What is Whistleblowing?

Whistleblowing is the disclosure of information about wrongdoing. A whistleblower is someone who reports certain types of wrongdoing that they have witnessed or become aware of.

The wrongdoing disclosed must be in the public interest, meaning it must affect others beyond the individual making the disclosure. This could include the Charity's beneficiaries, donors, the wider community, or the public generally.

A concern can be raised at any time about an incident that happened in the past, is happening now, or is believed will happen in the near future.

5. What Can Be Reported Under This Policy?

This policy covers concerns about wrongdoing including, but not limited to:

- Criminal activity or breach of the law
- Fraud, theft, or financial irregularities
- Corruption or bribery
- Misuse or misappropriation of charitable funds or assets
- Breach of the Charity's governing document or policies
- Serious health and safety risks
- Safeguarding concerns (abuse or risk of harm to children or vulnerable adults)
- Abuse of authority or position
- Bullying, harassment, or discrimination
- Money laundering or terrorist financing
- Breach of data protection requirements
- Deliberate concealment of any of the above
- Other serious unethical conduct

6. What is Not Covered by This Policy?

This policy is not intended to cover:

- **Personal grievances:** Concerns about your own treatment (such as a dispute about how you have been treated as a volunteer) should be raised under the Complaints Policy or through your trustee contact
- **Complaints about the Charity's services:** These should be raised under the Complaints Policy
- **Disagreements about decisions:** Disagreement with a decision made by the Board, where there is no suggestion of wrongdoing, is not a matter for this policy

If you are unsure whether your concern falls within this policy, you are encouraged to raise it anyway and it will be directed to the appropriate process.

7. How to Raise a Concern

7.1 Who to Report To

Concerns should be reported to:

- **The Whistleblowing Lead:** The Board will appoint a trustee as the Whistleblowing Lead. Their contact details are shown on the front page of this policy and will be made available on the Charity's website
- **The Chair:** If the concern involves the Whistleblowing Lead, or if you prefer, you may report to the Chair
- **Another trustee:** If the concern involves both the Whistleblowing Lead and the Chair, you may report to any other trustee. Trustee contact details are available on the Charity Commission website

7.2 How to Report

Concerns may be raised verbally (in person or by telephone) or in writing (by letter or email). Written reports are encouraged as they help ensure that the information is accurately recorded.

7.3 What Information to Provide

When raising a concern, please provide as much relevant information as possible, including:

- Your name and contact details (unless you wish to remain anonymous – see Section 10)
- The nature of the concern and why you believe wrongdoing has occurred, is occurring, or may occur
- Relevant dates, times, and locations
- Names of anyone involved or who may be able to provide relevant information
- Any documentary evidence or other supporting information

You are not expected to prove your allegation, but you do need to provide sufficient information to establish a reasonable basis for the concern.

8. How Concerns Will Be Handled

8.1 Initial Response

The person receiving the concern (the Whistleblowing Lead, Chair, or other trustee) will:

- Acknowledge receipt of the concern, normally within 5 working days
- Make an initial assessment to determine whether the concern falls within this policy and whether an investigation is warranted
- Inform the person raising the concern of the next steps, where possible

8.2 Investigation

If an investigation is required, it will be conducted promptly, thoroughly, and impartially. The scope and nature of the investigation will depend on the nature and seriousness of the concern. In some cases, it may be appropriate to involve external parties, such as the police, the Charity Commission, or independent investigators.

The person raising the concern will be kept informed of progress where appropriate and possible, subject to any legal constraints and considerations of confidentiality.

8.3 Outcome

Once the investigation is complete, the person raising the concern will be informed of the outcome, to the extent that confidentiality and legal considerations permit. The Charity will take appropriate action based on the findings, which may include reporting matters to the Charity Commission, police, or other authorities.

9. Confidentiality

All concerns will be treated in confidence. Every effort will be made to protect the identity of the person raising the concern, unless they consent to being identified or disclosure is required by law.

However, in some circumstances it may not be possible to maintain confidentiality – for example, if the matter results in legal proceedings or if disclosure is necessary to properly investigate the concern. In such cases, the person raising the concern will be informed and supported.

10. Anonymous Concerns

The Charity encourages individuals to put their name to any concern raised, as this makes it easier to investigate and to provide feedback. Anonymous concerns are more difficult to investigate and may be given less weight.

However, anonymous concerns will be considered, taking into account:

- The seriousness of the issue raised
- The credibility of the concern
- Whether the concern can be investigated without knowing the identity of the person who raised it

11. Protection for Whistleblowers

The Charity is committed to protecting those who raise genuine concerns in good faith:

- No one will be subjected to any detriment, harassment, or unfair treatment for raising a concern in good faith under this policy
- Any trustee or volunteer who victimises someone for raising a concern will be subject to appropriate action
- The Charity will support anyone who raises a concern and experiences difficulties as a result
- Concerns about victimisation should be reported immediately to the Chair or another trustee

Individuals who are "workers" (in the legal sense) have specific legal protections under the Public Interest Disclosure Act 1998 (often referred to as whistleblowing legislation). While the Charity does not currently employ staff, the Charity is committed to extending the same protections to all its volunteers.

12. Untrue or Malicious Allegations

No action will be taken against anyone who raises a concern in the reasonable belief that it is in the public interest to do so, even if the concern is not subsequently substantiated by investigation.

However, making allegations that are known to be false, or that are made maliciously, frivolously, or for personal gain, is a serious matter. Anyone who makes such allegations may be subject to appropriate action and may also face legal consequences.

13. External Reporting

The Charity hopes that anyone with concerns will feel able to raise them internally in the first instance. However, there may be circumstances where it is appropriate to report concerns to an external body.

External bodies to whom concerns may be reported include:

- **Charity Commission:** The regulator for charities in England and Wales. Concerns can be reported via their website or by email to whistleblowing@charitycommission.gov.uk
- **Police:** Where there is evidence of criminal activity
- **National Crime Agency:** For concerns about money laundering or terrorist financing
- **Information Commissioner's Office:** For concerns about data protection breaches

- **Protect (formerly Public Concern at Work):** An independent charity that provides confidential advice and support to whistleblowers. Website: www.protect-advice.org.uk

14. Review

This policy will be reviewed by the Board of Trustees every two years, or sooner if there are significant changes to relevant legislation or best practice guidance.

15. Related Guidance

Charity Commission Guidance:

- Whistleblowing
- How to report a serious incident in your charity
- Reporting serious incidents to the Charity Commission

Other Guidance:

- Department for Business and Trade: Whistleblowing: guidance and code of practice for employers
- GOV.UK: Whistleblowing for employees
- Protect: Resources and advice for whistleblowers

16. Approval and Version History

Version	Date	Approved By	Changes
1.0	01/02/2026	Board of Trustees	Initial policy

17. Trustee Declaration

We, the undersigned trustees of Gloucester Zakat Charity, confirm that we have read, understood, and approved this Whistleblowing Policy and commit to its implementation.

Name	Role	Signature	Date
Mr Abdullah Abdul Samad Patel	Chair	A. Patel	01/02/2026
Mr Kamel Boulkenafet	Trustee	K. Boulkenafet	01/02/2026
Mr Hashim Moolla	Trustee	H. Moolla	01/02/2026
Mr Farouq Ginwalla	Trustee	F. Ginwalla	01/02/2026
Ms Mariam Qureshi	Trustee	M. Qureshi	01/02/2026

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